

TPL-12 · FREE TEMPLATES

Change order log

Every change, its status, its dates — and whether it is in the forecast

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A change order log that tracks each change from first identification to agreement, records the date of every status transition, keeps the submitted, assessed and best-estimate values apart, and carries the one column most logs omit: whether the change is in the cost forecast, and for how much. The difference between the best estimate and the amount in the forecast is unrecognised exposure, and this log adds it up.

— About this document

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Change order log

In one paragraph. A change order log that tracks each change from first identification to agreement, records the date of every status transition, keeps the submitted, assessed and best-estimate values apart, and carries the one column most logs omit: whether the change is in the cost forecast, and for how much. The difference between the best estimate and the amount in the forecast is unrecognised exposure, and this log adds it up.

Who this is for. Quantity surveyors, commercial managers, cost engineers and project controls managers who run the change process; and the project managers and finance partners who rely on a forecast that only holds if this log is complete.

— 1. When to use this

Open it on day one, before the first change arrives, because the fields you cannot reconstruct are the early ones — the date something was first identified, and whether a notice was served in time.

It does three jobs that nothing else does.

It protects entitlement. Most contracts make some relief conditional on notice, and some make it a strict condition. The notice block in columns I to N is the part of this log that has to be right, and it is the part most often filled in retrospectively, which is to say wrongly.

It keeps the forecast honest. A change with a real cost that is not in the forecast is a loss that has already happened and has not yet been reported. Columns AE to AH exist to make that visible before the month closes rather than at the final account.

It is the audit trail. When a change is disputed a year later, the argument is almost always about sequence: what was known, when, and what was said about it. A log with a date against every status transition answers that in one row.

It is not a substitute for the baseline change control process. A change to scope may or may not change the baseline, and the two are separate decisions with separate approvals — [TPL-04 – Baseline change request](#) is where that lives. This log tracks the commercial event; the baseline change request tracks what happens to the measurement of performance.

— 2. How to complete it

2.1 Register it the day it appears, not the day it is agreed

The trigger for a row is the moment somebody becomes aware that the work may change — not the instruction, not the quotation, not the agreement. Registering late is how notice periods are missed and how the log ends up describing an outcome instead of a process. If it turns out not to be a change, close the row as Withdrawn with a reason; a log with withdrawn rows in it is a log somebody is actually using.

2.2 Get the notice block right first

Column I asks whether notice is required, column J records the date of the trigger, and column K records the notice period. Two points make the difference between a useful record and a misleading one.

Know what starts the clock in your contract. Some contracts run the period from the occurrence, some from the date the party became aware, and some from the date the party ought reasonably to have become aware. These are different dates and they lead to different answers. Record in column J the date that starts the clock under your contract, and note in column AS which test you applied.

Record the position honestly, including when it is bad. Column N calculates whether the notice was served inside the period. If it was not, the log should say so. A commercial team that discovers a late notice in month four has options; one that discovers it in the final account has an argument it will probably lose. Whether a late notice defeats entitlement, and what relief remains if it does, depends on the contract and the law governing it — this log records the fact, not the consequence.

2.3 Keep three cost figures apart

Column W is what was submitted. Column X is what the other party has assessed. Column Y is the current best estimate — the number the commercial team genuinely expects to settle at, which is usually neither of the other two.

Merging them destroys the log. If you record only the submitted value, the forecast is optimistic and the gap in column Z is invisible. If you record only the assessed value, you have adopted the other side's position in your own forecast. If you record only the best estimate, you cannot show anyone how far apart the parties are, which is the information a negotiation strategy is built from.

The same logic applies to time. Column AA is the days claimed, column AB the days agreed, and column AJ the days actually reflected in the current schedule — three different numbers that are routinely assumed to be one.

2.4 Answer the forecast question every month

Column AE takes Yes, No or Partial. Column AF takes the amount actually included. Column AG records the basis — agreed value, assessed value, best estimate, risk-adjusted, or nil.

This is the column that saves people, and it saves them in a specific way. The failure it prevents is not dishonesty; it is a handover gap. The commercial team knows a change is worth 240,000 and is confident of recovering it. The cost engineer does not include it in the forecast because it is not agreed. Neither is wrong, and both are behaving reasonably. The result is a forecast that is 240,000 light and a commercial position that nobody has priced. The gap lives in the space between two competent people, and a single column closes it.

State the convention the project uses for what goes into the forecast, and apply it to every row. Any convention is defensible — include the assessed value, include the best estimate, include a risk-adjusted value — provided it is written down, applied consistently, and the unrecognised exposure in column AH is reported alongside the forecast rather than instead of it.

2.5 Use a report date, not today

Every date-difference formula below uses a named cell called [Report_Date](#) rather than [TODAY\(\)](#). This matters more than it sounds: a log built on [TODAY\(\)](#) produces different numbers every time it is opened, so the log attached to March's report no longer agrees with March's report by April. Set [Report_Date](#) to the reporting cut-off, and the log is reproducible.

— 3. The template

Header row in row 1, data from row 2. Formulas are written for row 2 and fill down. [Report_Date](#) and [Original_Contract_Value](#) are named cells on a [Parameters](#) sheet.

3.1 Input columns

Col	Field	What goes in it
A	Change ID	Permanent, never reused, e.g. CHG-018
B	Date first identified	When somebody first became aware the work might change
C	Origin	Client instruction · Design development · Site condition · Statutory or consent · Supply chain · Error or omission · Opportunity · Scope clarification
D	Originator	Named individual and organisation
E	Description	One sentence saying what changes. Not why, not who is to blame
F	Affected WBS or control account	Where the cost lands
G	Affected activity IDs	Where the time lands, in schedule identifiers
H	Contract mechanism relied on	The mechanism in general terms — variation, compensation event, change order, claim. Record the clause reference from your executed contract, not from memory of a standard form
I	Notice required?	Yes · No · Unknown
J	Notice trigger date	The date that starts the clock under your contract
K	Notice period (days)	From the contract. Note in column AS whether these are calendar or working days
M	Notice served date	
O	Status	Notified · Quoted · Instructed · Agreed · Disputed · Withdrawn · Rejected
P-T	Date notified · quoted · instructed · agreed · disputed	One date per transition, left blank until it happens. Never overwrite an earlier one
W	Cost — submitted	The value submitted
X	Cost — assessed	The value assessed by the other party
Y	Cost — current best estimate	What the commercial team expects to settle at
AA	Schedule — days claimed	
AB	Schedule — days agreed	
AD	Commercial position	Agreed · In negotiation · Gap noted · Reserved · Referred
AE	In the cost forecast?	Yes · No · Partial
AF	Amount included in the forecast	Currency
AG	Basis of inclusion	Agreed value · Assessed value · Best estimate · Risk-adjusted · Nil
AI	In the schedule?	Yes · No · Partial
AJ	Days reflected in the current schedule	
AL	Approval reference	Instruction number, minute reference, signed order reference
AM	Approved by	Named individual with the authority to approve
AN		

Col	Field	What goes in it
	Payment application first included in	
AO	Linked risk ID	Where the change is a realised risk, the ID from TPL-10
AP	Owner	The named person progressing this change
AQ	Next action	
AR	Next action date	
AS	Notes	Including which notice test applied, whether the period is calendar or working days, and any reservation

3.2 Calculated columns

Col	Field	Formula in words	Spreadsheet expression
L	Notice due date	The trigger date plus the notice period, where notice is required	<code>=IF(OR(\$I2<>"Yes", \$J2="", \$K2=""), "", \$J2+\$K2)</code>
N	Notice position	Not required where no notice applies; otherwise whether it was served, served in time, or the period has expired unserved	<code>=IF(\$I2<>"Yes", "Not required", IF(\$M2="", IF(AND(\$L2<>"", Report_Date>\$L2), "Not served – period expired", "Not served"), IF(\$M2<=\$L2, "Served within the period", "Served late")))</code>
U	Date of latest status change	The most recent of the five transition dates; blank if none has occurred	<code>=IF(MAX(\$P2:\$T2)=0, "", MAX(\$P2:\$T2))</code>
V	Days in current status	Days from the latest transition to the report date	<code>=IF(\$U2="", "", Report_Date-\$U2)</code>
Z	Cost gap	Submitted less assessed; blank until both exist	<code>=IF(COUNT(\$W2:\$X2)<2, "", \$W2-\$X2)</code>
AC	Schedule gap	Days claimed less days agreed; blank until both exist	<code>=IF(COUNT(\$AA2:\$AB2)<2, "", \$AA2-\$AB2)</code>
AH	Unrecognised cost exposure	Best estimate less the amount included in the forecast, treating a blank inclusion as zero	<code>=IF(\$Y2="", "", \$Y2-N(\$AF2))</code>
AK	Unrecognised time exposure	Days claimed less days reflected in the current schedule, treating a blank as zero	<code>=IF(\$AA2="", "", \$AA2-N(\$AJ2))</code>

Summary cells, to be placed above the log and read at every monthly review:

Field	Formula in words	Spreadsheet expression
Total current best estimate	Sum of the best-estimate column	=SUM(\$Y:\$Y)
Total in the forecast	Sum of the amounts included	=SUM(\$AF:\$AF)
Total unrecognised cost exposure	Sum of the exposure column	=SUM(\$AH:\$AH)
Share of change value not in the forecast	Unrecognised exposure divided by total best estimate; blank if there is no change value	=IF(SUM(\$Y:\$Y)=0,"",SUM(\$AH:\$AH)/SUM(\$Y:\$Y))
Change value as a share of the original contract	Total best estimate divided by the original contract value; blank if that value is unset	=IF(N(Original_Contract_Value)=0,"",SUM(\$Y:\$Y)/Original_Contract_Value)
Notices at risk	Count of rows where the notice period has expired without service	=COUNTIF(\$N:\$N,"Not served – period expired")
Total unrecognised time exposure	Sum of the time-exposure column	=SUM(\$AK:\$AK)

3.3 Pasting it into a spreadsheet

Copy the header line into cell A1 and split on the pipe character. Format the date columns, set **Report Date** on the **Parameters** sheet, then apply the §3.2 formulas to row 2 and fill down.

```
Change ID|Date first identified|Origin|Originator|Description|Affected WBS|Affected activity IDs|Contract mechanism|Notice required?|Notice trigger date|Notice period (days)|Notice due date|Notice served date|Notice position|Status|Date notified|Date quoted|Date instructed|Date agreed|Date disputed|Latest status change|Days in current status|Cost submitted|Cost assessed|Cost best estimate|Cost gap|Days claimed|Days agreed|Schedule gap|Commercial position|In the cost forecast?|Amount in forecast|Basis of inclusion|Unrecognised cost exposure|In the schedule?|Days reflected in schedule|Unrecognised time exposure|Approval reference|Approved by|Application first included|Linked risk ID|Owner|Next action|Next action date|Notes
```

In Markdown, split it into three blocks sharing the change ID: identification and notice (A to N), status and value (O to AD), and forecast and approval (AE to AS).

4. Worked fragment

Illustrative figures. Currency-neutral units. Report date 30 April 2026. Notice periods in calendar days. Original contract value 24,000,000.

Identification and notice

Change ID	Origin	Description	Notice required?	Trigger date	Period	Due	Served	Notice position
CHG-011	Design development	Revised louvre specification to the plant room façade	No	—	—	—	—	Not required
CHG-018	Client instruction	Additional fire dampers to the level 3 riser	No	—	—	—	—	Not required
CHG-023	Site condition	Buried services encountered on the southern access route	Yes	4 Mar 26	14	18 Mar 26	16 Mar 26	Served within the period

Status and value

Change ID	Status	Latest transition	Days in status	Submitted	Assessed	Best estimate	Cost gap	Days claimed	Days agreed	Schedule gap
CHG-011	Agreed	13 Feb 26	76	62,000	62,000	62,000	0	0	0	0
CHG-018	Instructed	6 Mar 26	55	148,000	96,000	120,000	52,000	5	0	5
CHG-023	Notified	16 Mar 26	45	—	—	240,000	—	12	—	—

Forecast position

Change ID	In the forecast?	Amount in forecast	Basis	Unrecognised cost exposure	In the schedule?	Days in schedule	Unrecognised time exposure
CHG-011	Yes	62,000	Agreed value	0	Yes	0	0
CHG-018	Partial	96,000	Assessed value	24,000	No	0	5
CHG-023	No	0	Nil	240,000	No	0	12

The substitutions.

CHG-023 notice due date: 4 March 2026 + 14 days = 18 March 2026. Served 16 March, which is on or before 18 March, so the position is "Served within the period".

CHG-018 days in current status: latest transition 6 March 2026, report date 30 April 2026, so 30 April – 6 March = 55 days. CHG-011: 30 April – 13 February = 76 days. CHG-023: 30 April – 16 March = 45 days.

CHG-018 unrecognised cost exposure: 120,000 – 96,000 = 24,000. CHG-023: 240,000 – 0 = 240,000. CHG-011: 62,000 – 62,000 = 0.

Totals: current best estimate 120,000 + 240,000 + 62,000 = 422,000. Amount in the forecast 96,000 + 0 + 62,000 = 158,000. Unrecognised cost exposure 24,000 + 240,000 + 0 = 264,000, and as a check, 158,000 + 264,000 = 422,000. Share of change value not in the forecast: 264,000 ÷ 422,000 = 0.626, or 62.6 %. Total unrecognised time exposure: 0 + 5 + 12 = 17 working days.

What the fragment is telling you. Every one of these three changes is being competently managed. Each has an owner, a status and a next action, and anyone reviewing the log would say the change process is working. And the cost forecast is understating this project by 264,000 — nearly two-thirds of the change value on the log — while the schedule carries none of the 17 days claimed. Neither of those two facts appears anywhere in a change log without columns AE to AK. That is the entire argument for the template.

The second reading is about CHG-018: it has been Instructed for 55 days with a 52,000 gap between what was submitted and what was assessed, and no date in the Agreed column. A change that has been instructed but not agreed is work being executed at a price nobody has settled, and 55 days is long enough for the record of what was actually done to start degrading. That row is the one for the commercial meeting.

— 5. Common mistakes

Registering changes when they are instructed. By then the notice period may have run and the early factual record — what was known and when — is already being reconstructed from memory.

One cost column. The submitted, assessed and best-estimate figures are three different pieces of information and they are needed for three different purposes. A log with one column has thrown two of them away.

Overwriting status dates. Columns P to T are a history, not a status field. Overwriting the notified date with the instructed date destroys the only record of how long each stage took, which is exactly what is argued about later.

Blank forecast columns. The most dangerous state of column AE is empty, because empty reads as "not yet considered" and behaves as "no". Every row should carry Yes, No or Partial by the monthly cut-off, even if the answer is No with a reason.

Adopting the other side's assessment as your forecast. Putting the assessed value into the forecast and leaving column Y unpopulated makes the gap disappear from your own reporting. Keep the best estimate, report the exposure, and let the negotiation be about a number that is visible.

A log that never closes rows. Agreed, Withdrawn and Rejected are terminal statuses with dates. A log where nothing ever leaves is one nobody trusts, and the summary totals become meaningless because settled changes are still counted as exposure.

Time impacts tracked only in days claimed. Column AJ — days actually reflected in the schedule — is the time equivalent of the forecast column, and it is omitted even more often. A schedule that does not carry the agreed extensions will show a completion date the project cannot achieve and cannot explain.

Using TODAY(). Covered in §2.5. A saved report should say the same thing next month as it said this month.

— 6. Adapting it

Safe to change. The origin taxonomy, the status list, the currency, and the addition of columns your contract or governance requires — a package reference, a client reference number, a sub-contract flow-down identifier, a retention or bond consequence. If your contract has more status stages than the five here, add a date column for each rather than reusing one.

Safe to add. A margin block, showing the value, the cost and the margin on each change, which is how a contractor finds out that the changes it fought hardest for were the least profitable. A cumulative chart of best estimate against amount in the forecast over time, which shows whether the gap is being closed or grown. A column for the party bearing the risk, where a change flows down to a subcontractor.

Do not change. The separation of submitted, assessed and best estimate. The dated status transitions. The notice block. And columns AE to AH — if you take one thing from this template into a log you already have, take those.

6.1 Before the monthly cut-off

- Every change identified this period has a row, including the ones that may turn out not to be changes.
- Every row where notice is required has a trigger date, a period, and a served date or an explanation.
- No row shows "Not served — period expired" without an entry in the notes and an escalation.
- Every row has a current best estimate, including rows that have not been quoted.
- Every row carries Yes, No or Partial in the forecast column, with a basis.
- The unrecognised cost exposure total has been given to whoever owns the cost forecast, in writing.
- The unrecognised time exposure total has been given to whoever owns the schedule, in writing.
- Any row instructed more than one reporting period ago and still not agreed is on the commercial agenda.
- Terminal rows have been closed with a date, and the summary totals exclude them or are reported both ways.
- [Report_Date](#) is set to this period's cut-off before the log is issued.

— Related

- [BPG-11 – Change orders and variations](#) — the method: identification, valuation, negotiation and the behaviours that make a change process work
- [BPG-04 – Baselining and baseline change control](#) — why a commercial change and a baseline change are separate decisions with separate approvals
- [TPL-04 – Baseline change request](#) — the instrument that moves the baseline, once a change is agreed
- [TPL-13 – Claim and extension-of-time narrative structure](#) — where a disputed change goes when the commercial position does not resolve

- [BPG-09 – Estimate at completion – choosing and defending a method](#) — how the unrecognised exposure in column AH reaches the forecast

— Sources and standards

This is an original instrument developed by the Institute. It reproduces no third-party template, form or contract wording. The status sequence, the notice mechanics and the valuation stages described here are general commercial practice expressed in the Institute's own words. No standard form of contract is quoted and no clause number is cited: the mechanism, the notice test and the consequence of late notice are determined by the contract in front of you and by the law governing it, and nothing in this template should be read as advice on either.

— Status and version

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